Color Theory for Beginners: My Reviewer

Color is one of the first things people notice in an artwork, a jeepney design, or a social media post. This reviewer covers the basics for our Arts and Design class, from the color wheel to how colors affect feelings.

The Color Wheel

The color wheel is a circle that arranges colors in order so we can see how they relate. The traditional painter's wheel has twelve colors built in three levels.

- Primary colors: red, yellow, and blue. On the traditional wheel, these cannot be made by mixing other paints.
- Secondary colors: orange, green, and violet. Each is made by mixing two primaries. Red plus yellow gives orange, yellow plus blue gives green, and blue plus red gives violet.
- Tertiary colors: made by mixing a primary with the secondary next to it. Their names put the primary first, like red-orange, yellow-green, and blue-violet. There are six.

Easy count: three primaries, three secondaries, and six tertiaries make twelve.

The Three Properties of Color

- Hue: the name of the color family, like red, blue, or yellow-green. When someone asks "what color is that?", they are asking for the hue.
- Saturation or intensity: how pure or strong the color is. A highly saturated red is vivid, like a fresh siling labuyo. A low-saturation red looks dull, like faded brick.
- Value: how light or dark the color is. Pale blue has high value; navy blue has low value.

Tints, Shades, and Tones

These words describe adding white, black, or gray to a hue.

- Tint: a hue plus white. It becomes lighter and softer, like red turning into pink.
- Shade: a hue plus black. It becomes darker, like green turning into forest green.
- Tone: a hue plus gray. It becomes muted and calm, like many earth-tone interiors.

Memory trick: a shade is like the shadow under a tree, so it is darker. A tone is "toned down" with gray.

Warm and Cool Colors

Cut the wheel in half and one side feels warm, the other cool.

- Warm colors: red, orange, yellow, and the colors between them. They remind us of fire and the afternoon sun, and they tend to look like they come forward.
- Cool colors: blue, green, and violet. They remind us of the sea and the shade under a mango tree, and they tend to look like they move back.

This is why painters often make faraway mountains bluish, so they look more distant.

Color Schemes or Harmonies

A color scheme is a planned group of colors that look good together.

- Complementary: two colors directly opposite each other on the wheel, like blue and orange, red and green, or yellow and violet. They give the strongest contrast and make each other look brighter. Use one as the main color and the other as an accent.
- Analogous: about three colors next to each other on the wheel, like yellow, yellow-green, and green. They feel calm and natural, like a rice field.
- Triadic: three colors evenly spaced around the wheel, forming a triangle. Red, yellow, and blue are one example. Triadic schemes are lively but balanced.
- Split-complementary: a base color plus the two colors on either side of its complement. For example, blue with yellow-orange and red-orange. It has contrast but is less harsh than plain complementary, so it is easier for beginners.
- Monochromatic: one hue in different tints, shades, and tones. It always looks unified.

RGB and CMYK

Screens and printers mix color in opposite ways.

- RGB stands for red, green, and blue. It is additive color, meaning it mixes light. Phones, TVs, and monitors use it. All three at full strength give white; none gives black.
- CMYK stands for cyan, magenta, yellow, and key, which is black. It is subtractive color, meaning inks absorb or subtract parts of light. Printers use it. Mixing cyan, magenta, and yellow ink only gives a muddy near-black, so a separate black ink is added for crisp darks.

Practical tip: a tarpaulin designed on your laptop in RGB may print with duller neon greens and blues. Ask the print shop if they want CMYK files, and do a test print if you can.

Color and Mood

Colors carry feelings, though meanings change with culture and context.

- Red: energy, passion, danger, or urgency. Sale signs and fast food logos often use it.
- Yellow: cheerfulness and attention. It also appears on warning signs.
- Blue: trust and calm, which is why banks and hospitals like it.
- Green: nature, health, and growth.
- Violet or purple: creativity, mystery, and in many cultures, royalty.
- Black: elegance, power, or grief.
- White: cleanliness, simplicity, and peace. In some cultures it is linked to mourning.

When choosing colors, think about your audience and message, not only your favorite color.

Quick check

- Q: What are the secondary colors on the traditional wheel? A: Orange, green, and violet.
- Q: What do you get when you add black to a hue? A: A shade.
- Q: Which scheme uses colors directly opposite each other on the wheel? A: Complementary.
- Q: Is RGB additive or subtractive? A: Additive, because it mixes light.
- Q: What does saturation describe? A: How pure, strong, or vivid a color is.